

NEEDY

The first time, I hadn't been the one to find her. Fall semester. Another roommate had got to her first after coming home from class early. Found her in the living room passed out on the couch. Blue.

Iris had started shouting without moving from the couch or calling or texting anyone. I'd been upstairs in my room that was a renovated closet, cheaper rent that way. I ran downstairs not in a hurry. I'd been annoyed. The shout had interrupted me in the middle of something. But Iris didn't shout much. She was one of the more level-headed of the nine/ten roommates. So I didn't hesitate in going to check what was up.

Alice passed out on the couch, blue and turning more blue. She was wearing crazy eyeliner like black lightning bolts across her face, or broken spider webs, and in parts on her cheeks the liner had smeared away.

"I found her like this." Iris turned to me, unfreezing at the sound of my steps down the stairs.

Her laptop unfolded on the couch, a blue supernova screensaver spinning. Alice herself splayed on the floor. Later she explained how she'd started the movie in her bedroom when she'd decided she wanted to watch on the big screen, meaning through the projector kept in the communal living room rigged with a bed sheet. That's how I knew it had been an accident.

I touched her body. I couldn't find a pulse. Iris called the ambulance. I performed CPR for the first time in my life with enough force to leave her with bruises later. I wanted to give her the kiss of life. I'd never kissed her before.

When the EMT arrived, I tried to be one of the first faces she saw when she came back to consciousness, after they stuck her with the Narcan. But her eyes didn't seem to be functioning

when she came to. Hollow, she scanned the room blindly with a look of distant horror. She started crying quietly—not sobbing but tears were streaming down her face, continuing to smear the liner—and apologizing to anyone within radius.

She answered the EMT’s questions obediently, diligently, like a good student under examination. She could not remember if it had been half a pill exactly because she cut them in uneven slices but tried to estimate the interval of time between slices. There had been multiple.

She used the same knife on her legs. An exacto-blade from an online Japanese stationary store embossed with cute characters. I saw it in her bedroom resting in the arms of a Snoopy plushie. I had only been invited into her room to visit the rabbit she was pet sitting over Halloween. The rabbit wasn’t very cute. It was albino and had red eyes. She also showed me the two broken phone cables it had chewed which was the reason it was no longer allowed outside the pen.

I saw the knife cuts on her legs when we went to the pier together to go swimming during one of the last warm weeks of the fall. The water was already freezing. Maybe she forgot. Probably she was looking for attention. She could’ve stayed on the dock with her skirt covering her legs but she decided to dive in with us. The cuts were fresh on her thighs, the scabs red and bumpy. The freakiest part was that it wasn’t straight lines like you’d imagine from the grayscale photos on emo Tumblr blogs but stupid shapes, like hearts and stars.

“Don’t you want to feel what it's like to be loved?”

I asked her during a conversation in late winter, after returning from break. We’d become friends all of a sudden, but if she wanted, I could be more to her. She’d been the first person I really wanted to talk to in the house. I hated the rest of them. I told her this. Maybe so that she'd feel flattered but she looked at me like she was sorry for me. She often looked at me like that. I

stopped minding so much when I realized she'd usually follow this look with a gesture of intimacy.

I started looking for ways to provoke this look. Her pity. I told her about my nightmares. Every night, sleep paralysis, demons, all of it. She prescribed me mugwort, dark chocolate and a journal. She used one to write her dreams down each night. In them, she'd fly with a flock of other winged children, sheltering them through the apocalypse, journeying through the same fantasy landscapes that existed only in her imagination but had become familiar after two decades sleeping.

I volunteered to accompany her anywhere. If she went walking to buy groceries at Trader Joes with her Snap benefits I kept her company. Even if I didn't want to walk in the cold, I couldn't let her out of my sight or the darkness would fall in around me.

I feared her abandoning me, how everyone else had. I told her how everyone I ever cared about, each had left me behind. She promised she could never.

Over fall break, I adopted a kitten. I didn't ask any of the roommates for permission before I did. I just brought her home one day from the shelter for \$75. Alice argued with me about it. Warned me that I wasn't ready to adopt an animal. A kitten meant a big commitment for the rest of its life. The kitten would grow up one day, start requiring medical visits, careful nutrition and other special attention. I told her she was being a bad sport.

We decided to get married. She'd brought it up herself, talking about financial aid. We sent the papers away the day before she left on winter break to New York.

I visited her for a weekend. She came up from Queens to meet me at Penn Station. We stayed up all night running around Times Square looking for any place still open, chastising the empty streets, "The city that never sleeps?!"

We drank a lot, hopping between corner stores. She walked back with me to my hotel before dawn. She slept beside me in the same bed, a king mattress, too spacious. I faced away from her. She didn't touch me but I could feel her looking at the back of my head. I held myself patiently. I could sense that if I made the slightest move she would've slipped away.

Over the holidays, we called each other to catch up over video. I asked her again why she married me. Her mother had been pissed. I hadn't told my parents. After the reasoning about financial aid, she said something along the lines of assuring our commitment to each other, cementing our friendship.

"I don't know how I feel about romantic marriage. I'm a child of divorce. I just need someone with me for the rest of my life."

The first time, she rode an ambulance to the hospital stuck with an IV drip or something. She flailed weakly as the EMTs pulled her into the gurney like a ragdoll. The second time, I rode beside her in the backseat driven by one of the roommates. She didn't need an ambulance but needed to remain under hospital supervision all the same in case the Narcan—which I had administered myself from the new emergency supply—wore off early and she had a seizure. She cried quietly the whole way. Apologizing every now and then to the driver. And to me. I don't know for what. Being an inconvenience. Giving us a scare.

By some sick joke of city planning, administrative incompetence, the hospital was at the top of a hill and we had to drive around ragged jack-knife turns all the way up. Each time the car swerved around a bend, she moaned. Every now and then she would whisper, "It hurts so much" or "I'm so cold" all the while looking out the window with a fixed expression, holding her folded arms stiffly across her chest and shivering. I thought about how she refused to kiss me that

second night. Maybe she was just too weak. Or nauseous. If I'd persisted, maybe she would've given in.

I tried to wait for her to be released but eventually I needed to go home. We were studying for midterm exams. I couldn't find out when she'd be cleared and her phone had died. She took a cab back. I welcomed her home. She offered me a juicebox. She had asked a nurse for food and been given peanut butter cups, boxes of orange juice and packs of saltines.

I made my first confession over text after my visit to New York. She responded, "That's hot, Rowan" then after some time, "We probably shouldn't be friends anymore. I don't feel the same at all."

We decided to stay friends. I assured her I could handle it. I could control my feelings. We lost touch anyway. Some weeks later I found out from Iris that she had met someone in New York. Someone she'd supposedly really fallen for. She'd asked Iris for advice on negotiating a long-distance relationship. I wanted to kill myself. Suddenly, everyone else in the house cared about how I was doing. Actually, I'd always felt that way but before I'd only told Alice and she'd always responded—with that look—that she could never leave me.

When she came back, she never talked about the guy she met but I pieced together from others that it hadn't worked out. She started warming up to my advances. After the night in Manhattan, I could feel how close I'd come to finally winning her over. It was the start of something. We were together like always but this time it was for real. She'd realized what I meant to her. That no one could ever love her like I loved her.

Sometimes, she'd go on grocery binges with her Snap benefits especially during her good mood swings. Once, she decided to make an ocean-theme cake decorated with as many themed

ingredients she could find. Swedish fish, gummy sharks, chocolate biscuit-crumble Pocky, pearl sprinkles, corn flakes and graham crackers for sand, all shades of frosting in green and blue.

She sculpted the foundation, a lemon chiffon cake, in three layers separated by lemon curd. She almost never cooked but on the rare occasions when she did she always cleaned simultaneously with a frenetic energy so that no dishes remained by the time the cake sat upon the table. She filmed the final result in a drunken frenzy, giggling, the flash blazing in my eyes. We cut slices. She poured us each a glass of coconut milk. She had a lactose intolerance.

Curled behind the glorious shipwreck in the corner of the kitchen, shimmering under candle light, she turned to me amongst the crowded collection of mismatched chairs and steered the conversation toward my previous advances. She had decided to take a chance, starting that night.

“What does it mean?”

“What you’ve been asking me. I’ll do it. I’ll be yours. Just not exclusive, if that’s okay.”

“That’s okay. But what do you mean ‘be mine?’”

“Whatever it means. Whatever people do.”

Despite her clouded speech, she seemed to mean something in specific. She wanted me to ask her first so she didn’t have to say it herself. I was tired but horny. I followed along.

We left the sweet crumbling rest for the roommates. I followed her downstairs to the bedroom, licking frosting from my fingers.

She didn’t have the bunny anymore. The bed was lined with plush dolls. An aquarium night light glowed in one corner. She closed her eyes and touched my upper body. I kissed her mouth. She turned over and fell asleep, still lying above the blankets. By the morning, she smelled awful, like sweat and something sour.

All the next day, I waited for sunset and the time to follow her downstairs again. In the evening at long-last, I giddily greeted the plush line up. Nothing changed from the previous night except that she turned her head away when I went to kiss her. Besides that, she fell asleep just as before, just as quickly without getting underneath the blankets. She smelled even worse in the morning. Like rotting fruit.

After the second night, she changed her mind back to the platonic previous and continued as if she'd never caved.

The look of pity slowly turned into disgust. I pretended not to notice. It was as if she did as well. It was as if, even if she wanted to, she could never leave me. Just as she had once promised. No one else in her life could be so loyal, so deeply and unswervingly dedicated to her. If this was the only way I could surpass the rest, to make myself irreplaceable to her, I had to excel in this area.

Instead, she slipped away until finally icing me out completely. We stayed living as roommates in the same house. I lived upstairs. She lived downstairs. The communal floor in between. But we never crossed paths. If she saw me coming her way, she turned the other direction. Same story on campus. When I couldn't take it anymore, I left a letter outside her door. She didn't respond. I lashed out. I apologized. Still she didn't respond.

The marriage papers hadn't been processed. I guarded my copy of the marriage license. She figured the clerk had probably dismissed the papers upon seeing that our minister was ordained by the church of life, or that we'd falsified the dates and the mailman had delivered the papers immediately despite the note she'd left on a post-it over the manila envelope tucked outside the mailbox, red flag propped up, before leaving on winter break, "Please wait 3 days before delivery".

The kitten ended up needing some medical attention I couldn't afford. Rather than ask my parents, I let Iris adopt the cat from me. Once small enough to hold in the palm of your hand, skinny like a soot sprite, she had grown large with long black fur that demanded constant brushing.

Alice started seeing another guy on campus, a year above us. She was with him the third and last time. He was either too drunk or stoned to even notice that she'd stopped breathing. His place was a mess, a total pigsty. I couldn't imagine how she tolerated the environment. The kitchen was stocked with dairy-free snacks from Trader Joes, probably purchased on Snap.